men a couple of days in advance to prepare for the discussion. You can argue this as an unfair practice—and it is, viewing it from the point of view of the other candidates—but here was a situation that made it imperative for me to get the candidate who would do as I directed. This was crucial for the mission, since anyone doubting the need for a liquid propulsion engine would be an impediment to the mission. And even while tipping off 'my men' to come prepared for discussions, I ensured the final selection was on merit. Their performance as part of the project later proved me right. My conscience remains clear.

I maintained this approach throughout the project, till 1980 when the last batch of our scientists returned and we eventually put together the Vikas engine (which till date is at the core of our Polar Satellite Launch Vehicles). Then I did not know I had adopted the philosophy of USA Today founder-editor Al Neuharth: be as nice as possible; only as nasty as necessary. It helped in dealing with some shortsighted Indian scientists; it triumphed over some shrewd French friends. That's another series of mind-and-matter episodes that would soon unfold in the beautiful countryside of Vernon, France.

When the final team was announced, complaints poured in that the team comprises only Nambi's men. I had expected this, and there was ample reason: no person from solid propulsion systems was selected for Operation Vernon. When a few rejected candidates complained this to Gowarikar, I asked a simple question, 'How could a solid propulsion man be in a liquid propulsion project?' That silenced the dissidents.

And then there were complaints that were absurd. One such was that I handpicked H S Panda because he was the son-in-law of Banamali Babu, a Congress MP from Orissa. Truth be told, I did not know about his background till the allegation surfaced. Panda was an IITian, and an excellent engineer. Those were reasons enough for me to have him in the team.

In four months, the team was ready. It had a few veterans of varied expertise, but many members were as young as in their twenties. The average age of the team was thirty. I, the team leader, was thirty-three.